

Themed Application

The Key to Building a Strong College Application



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Introduction

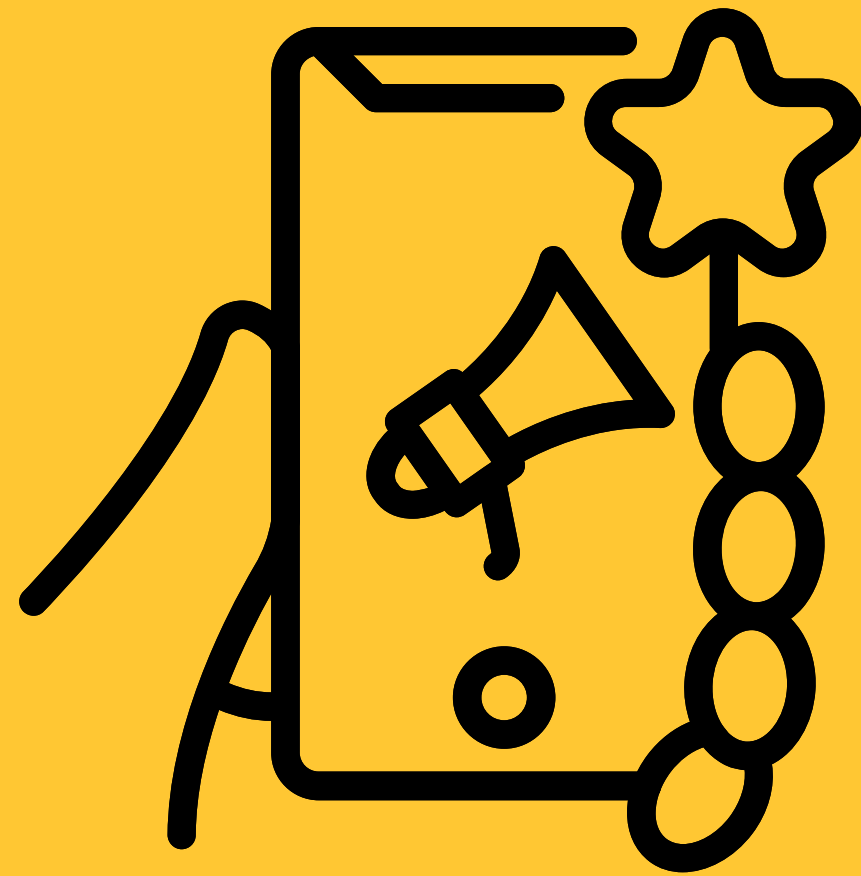


- A theme is a recurring topic(s) that unites the various components of your application.
- Your theme brings everything into focus and should allow your profile to be summarized in one or two words.
- Having a theme in a college application can help you stand out from other applicants and make a stronger impression on admissions officers.
- It can also help you showcase your unique strengths and experiences in a way that highlights your personal brand and identity.
- It all rolls down to the message you want to convey about yourself.

What is a Brand?



branding



branding

WHAT IS A BRAND?

A brand is a product, service or concept that is **publicly distinguished** from other products, services or concepts so that it can be easily communicated and usually marketed.

What is your job?

*To **sell** your brand to the Admission Officer(s) reading your application.*

Publicly Distinguished:

This should be a major concern in your application.

You should seek to answer the question:

With all that has been said in my application, who will the Admissions Officer remember me as?

THEME

VS

NARRATIVE

THEME



Developing a theme that clearly shows how you will be an asset to the college is an effective way to help you stand out among thousands of other applicants.



Connect the dots between the classes you took, the activities you participated in, and the college major you plan to pursue. Linking your activities, recommendation letters and the classes is vital in creating a compelling and logical theme.



Your theme brings everything into focus and should allow your profile to be summarized in one or two words.





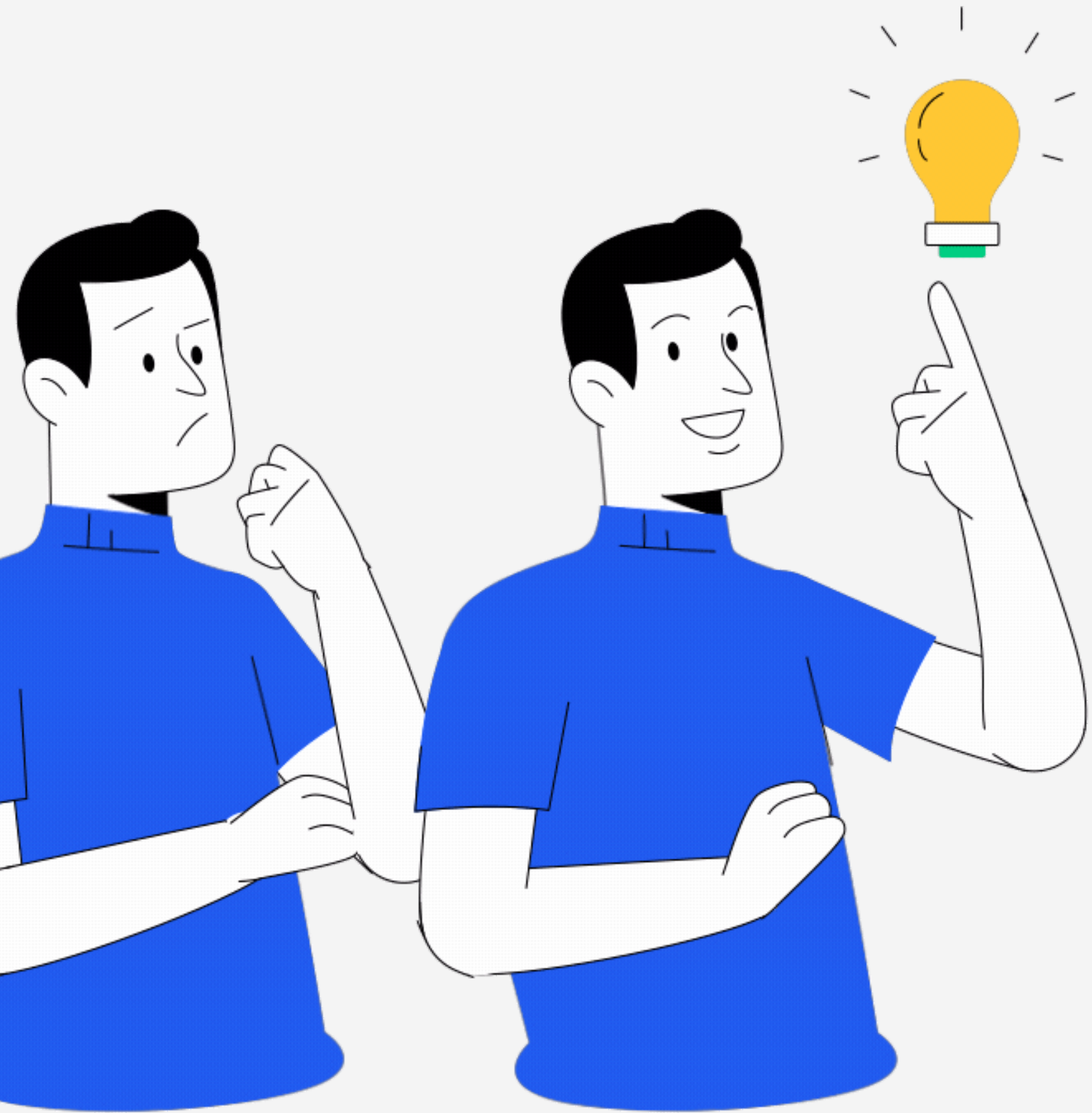
NARRATIVE

- 💡 While the theme is the central idea that every element in your profile ties into, the narrative is how you take the theme and tell your unique story.
- 💡 The theme is about the **what** and **how** while the narrative is about the **why**.
- 💡 Your profile should present Admission Officers with a sincere and interesting narrative that focuses on who you are rather than what you have done.
- 💡 The why is what differentiates yourself from other applicants since many applicants may have the same theme.
- 💡 The narrative should be unique to yourself. It will provide the necessary context for your theme and make everything logically fit together.



Why is a Theme Important?

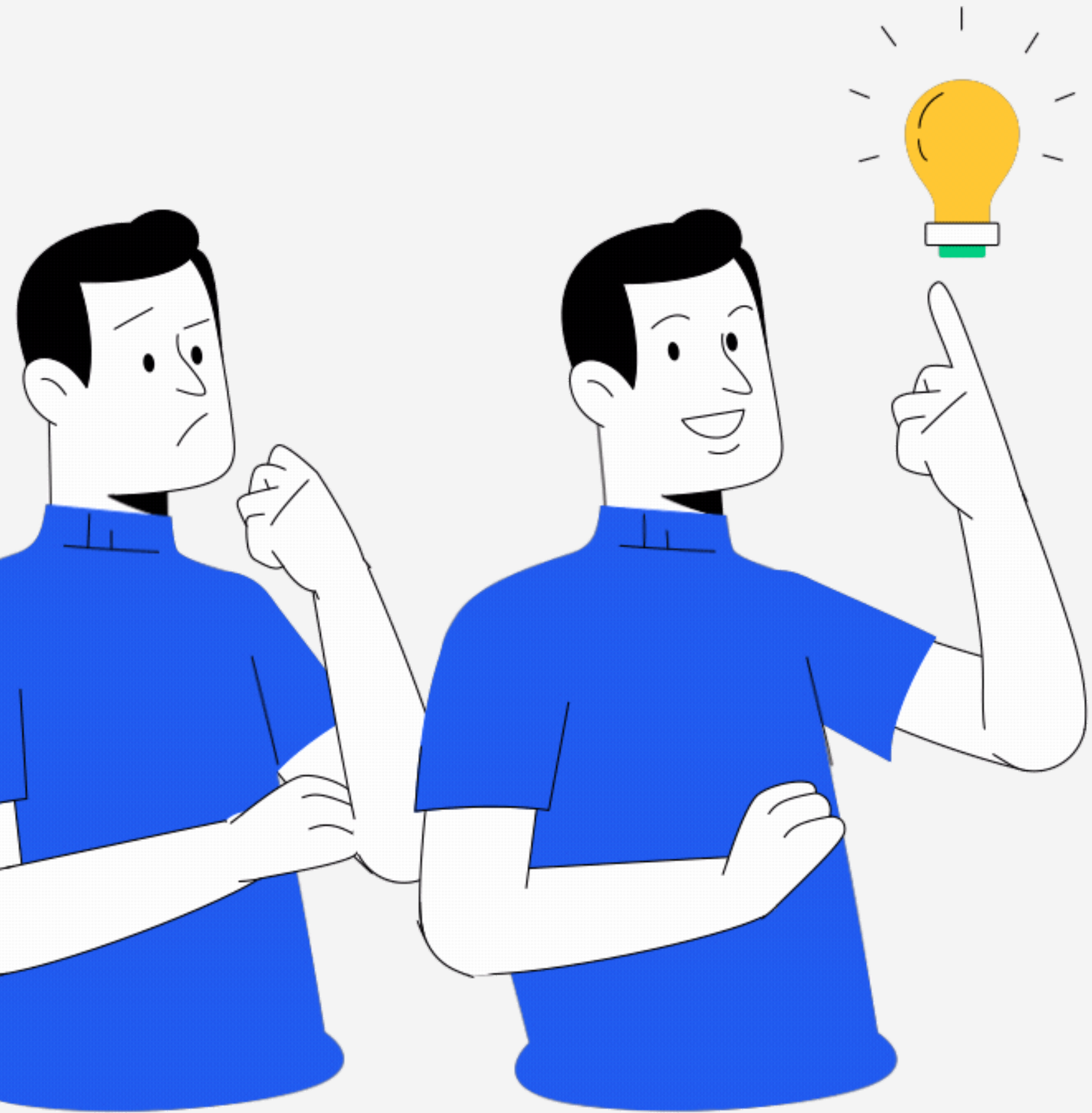
- It unifies the various elements of your application profile.
- A strong application theme can immediately set applicants apart while offering a clear and compelling story to college admission readers.
- Having a theme in mind can be particularly helpful when determining what essays to write and activities to present.



Possible Themes

Surface Level Themes

- Engineering
- Biology
- Computer Science
- Journalism
- Health
- Global Affairs
- Entrepreneurship
- Art/Music



Possible Themes

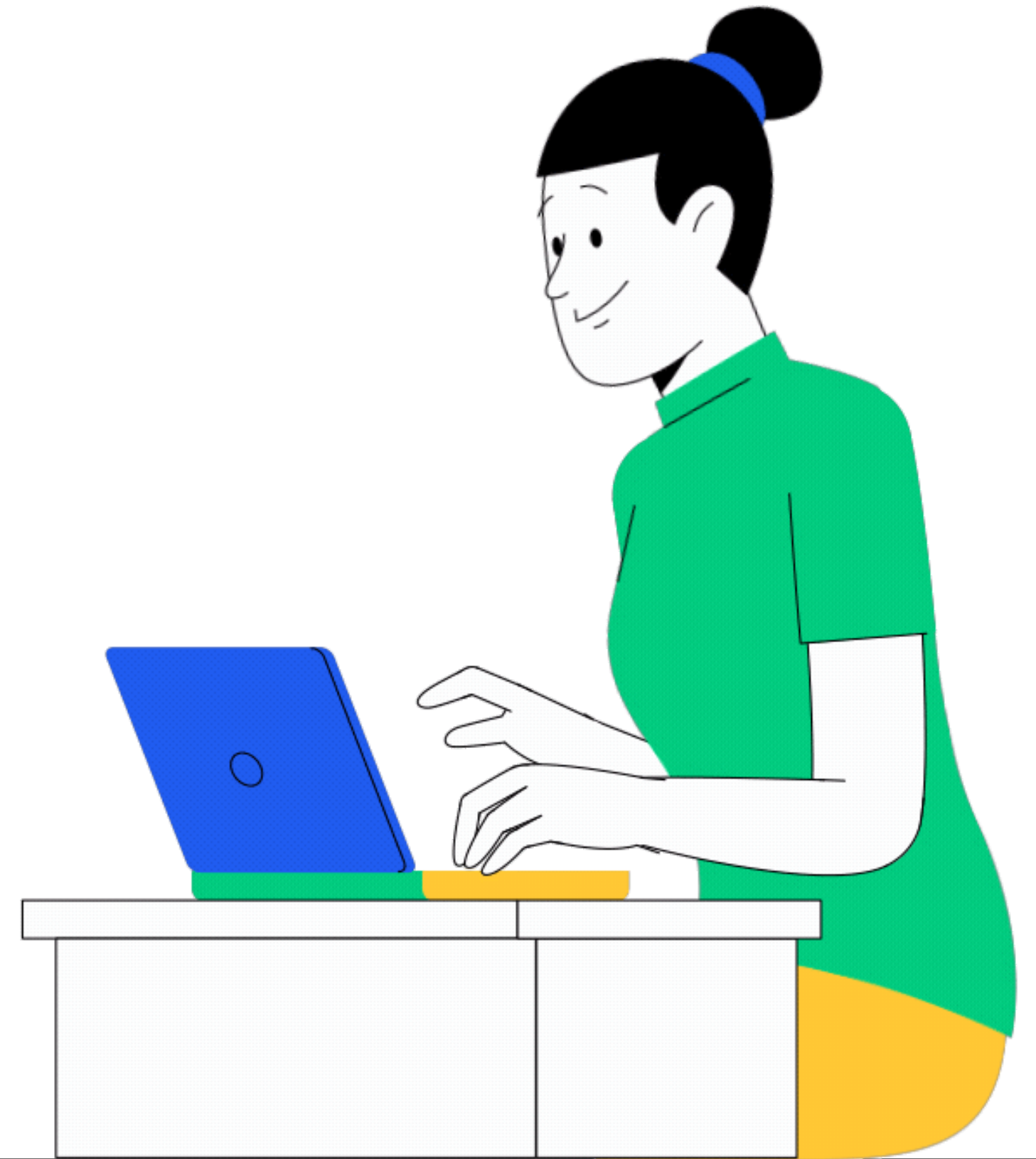
Nuanced Themes

- Leadership
- Relationships
- Personal Experience
- LGBTQAI+ Identity Card
- Cultural Background
- Immigrant Story/Status
- Ideologies

Constant Theme: Low Income Student with a Dream

How To Use Application Themes

How to use a potential theme to guide the content of your application.



1. Academic Interests

- What subjects did you take?
- How did you perform in them?



2. Extracurricular Activities

- How did you order your activities list?
- Start with activities that align with your deep interests.



3. Essays

- **Extracurricular Activity Essay** - Preferably describe an activity that aligns with your major of choice
- **Why Major Essay** - Ensure that an activity related to the major was mentioned in the extra-curricular profile
- **Why College Essay** - e.g it does not make sense to state that you are attracted to Northwestern by its school of journalism yet there is nowhere else in your application where a passion of journalism is hinted.
- **Common App Essay** - Themes that can be brought up include themes of family, relationship, diversity and demonstrated leadership.



4. Recommendation Letters

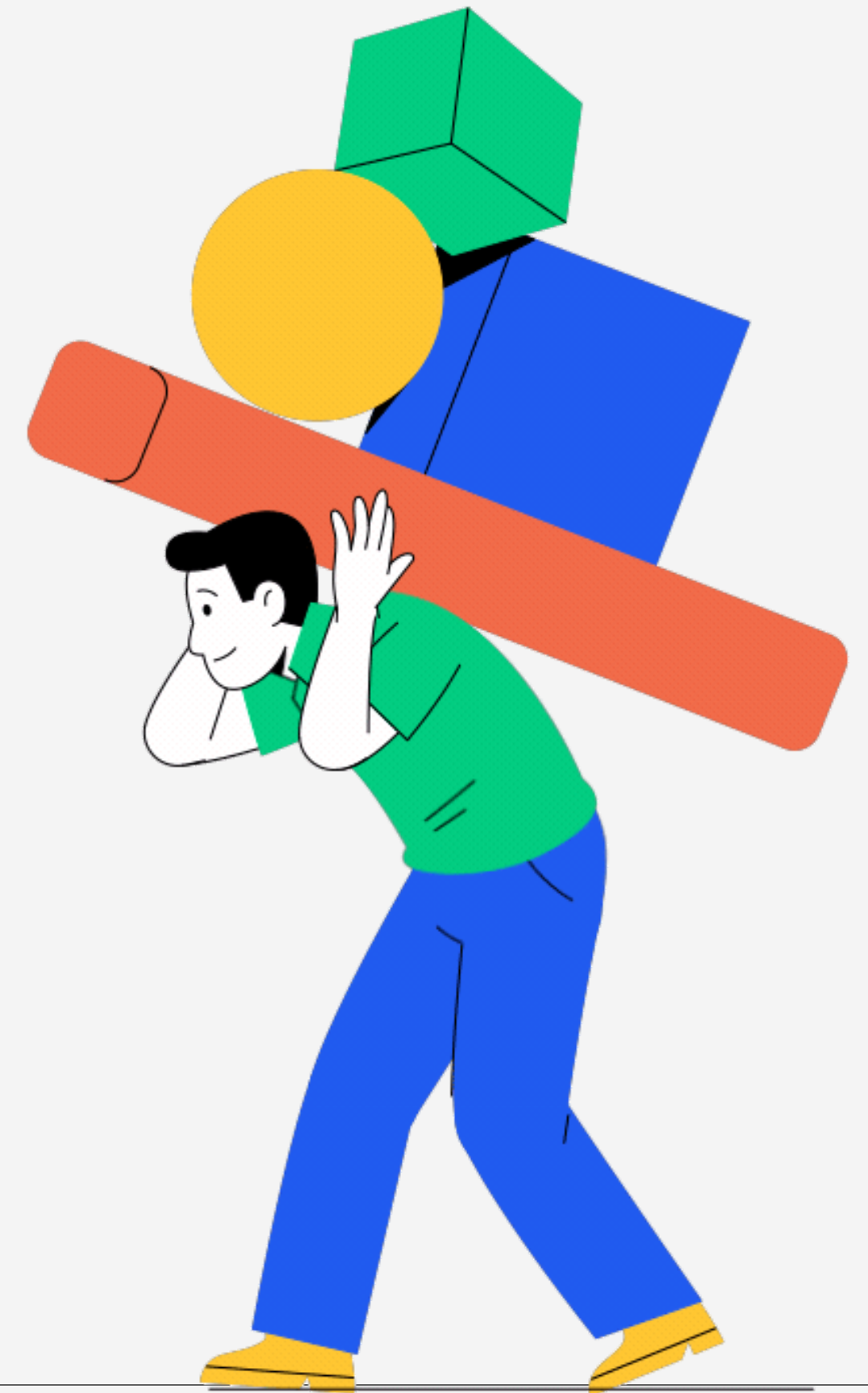
- It's only logical for aspiring math and science majors to seek out recommendations from teachers in those fields.
- You should provide recommenders with information about your hobbies and extracurriculars.
- It is advised that some of your mentioned activities are in the recommendations to enforce the theme and bring authenticity to your application.



The All-Rounded Approach



And how to hack them in your College Application.



POINTY

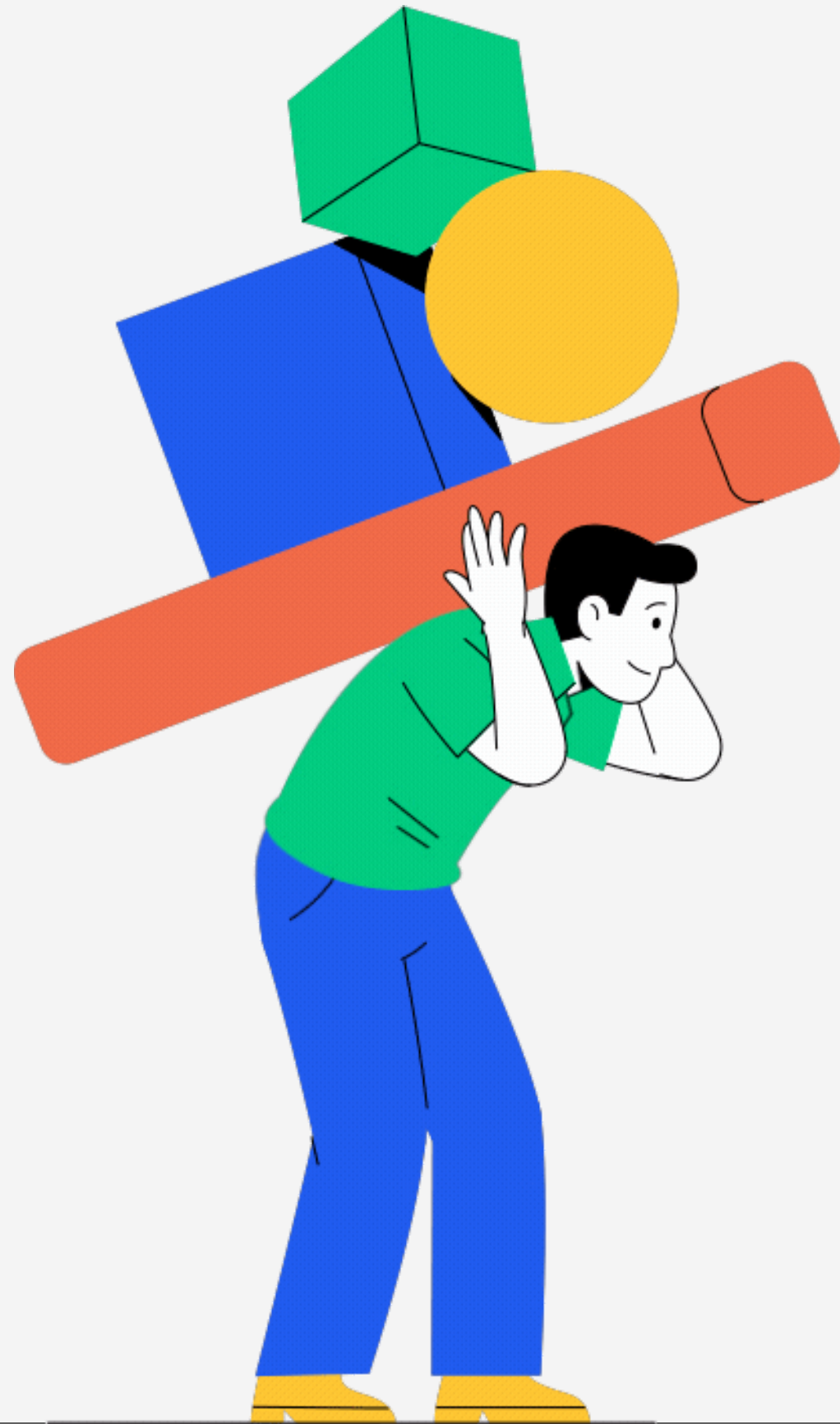
They have one dominant theme or passion that their entire application centers around.



VS

WELL- ROUNDED

Interested in a bunch of different things. You need to connect the variety of interests that you have. To well craft this, you will need to create a **"Through-Line"**



The Through-Line Concept

- You can have multiple things that you are interested in, but you need to make connections that will ensure your different interests relate.
- This will make your application more **cohesive** and **focused**.

Example of Through-Line in Use

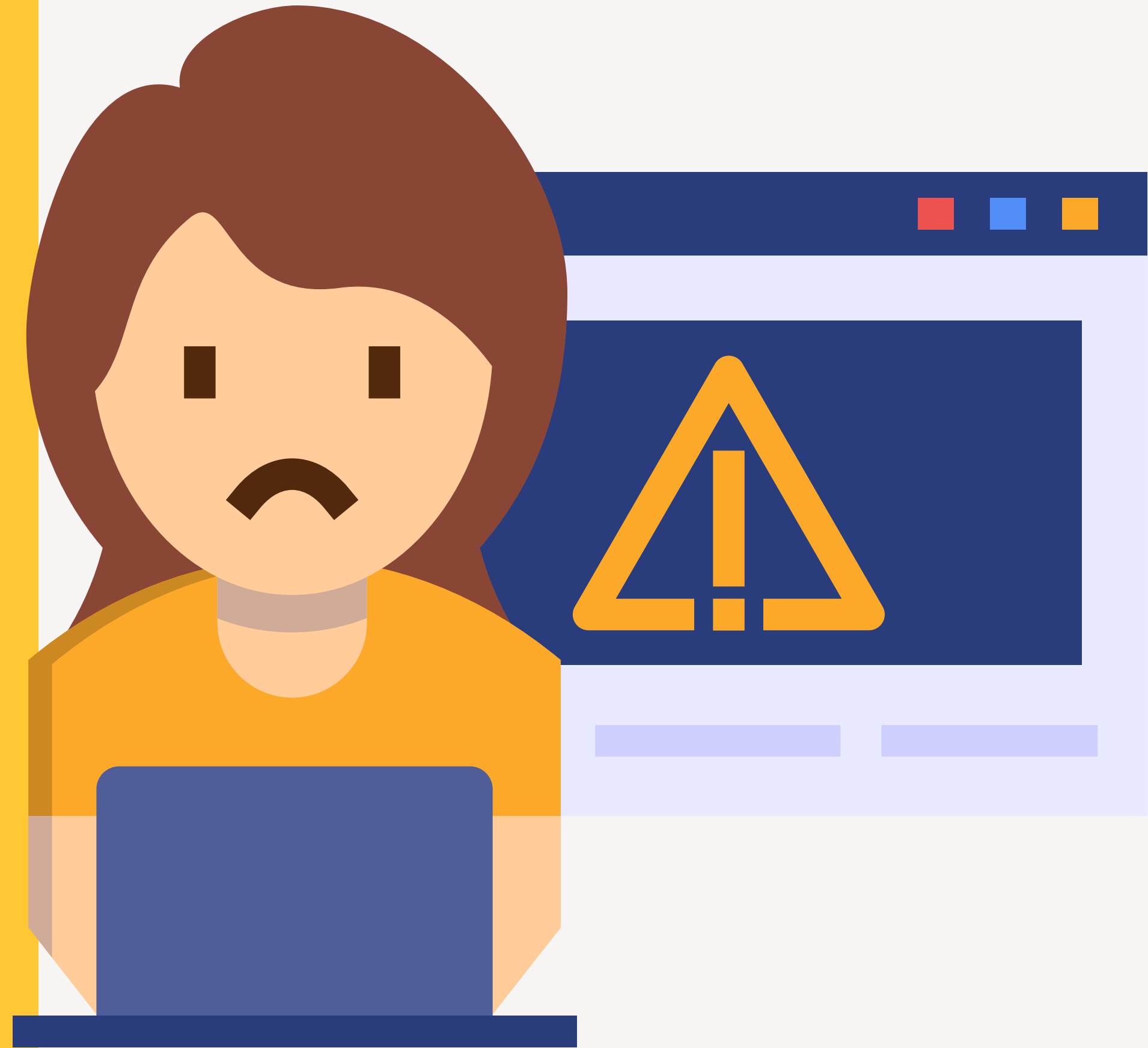
Maybe you play the piano and it does not relate to any of your academic interests since you want to study Chemical Engineering. In this case you can say that by through piano practice you learned the art of patience and learning through repetition. These skills consequently helped you review chemical terms and practice the periodic table for example.

Places To Craft a Through-Line Include:

- Essays
- Extra-Curricular Activities
- Interviews



Common Mistakes That Students Make When Choosing A Theme For Their Application.



MISTAKE #1:
CHOOSING A THEME THAT DOESN'T FIT YOUR PERSONALITY OR EXPERIENCES

- It is important to choose a theme that reflects who you are as a person and what you have accomplished.
- Don't try to force a theme that doesn't fit with your personality or experiences

MISTAKE #2:
CHOOSING A THEME THAT IS TOO BROAD OR VAGUE

- A theme that is too broad or vague can make it difficult to create a cohesive narrative for your application.
- Instead, choose a theme that is specific and focused.

MISTAKE #3: CHOOSING A THEME THAT IS OVERUSED

- Admission Officers have seen many applicants with similar themes, such as "leadership" or "community service".
- While these themes can be effective if executed well, it's important to find a unique angle that sets you apart from other applicants.

MISTAKE #4:

FOCUSING TOO MUCH ON THE THEME

- While having a theme can be helpful in creating a cohesive application, it's important not to force every aspect of your application to fit the theme.
- Make sure that you are highlighting all of your strengths and experiences, not just those that fit within the theme.

MISTAKE #5:

NEGLECTING TO SHOW PERSONAL QUALITIES

- While it's important to have a strong theme, it's also important to showcase your personal qualities, such as your character, personality and values.
- Admission Officers want to get a sense of who you are as a person, not just what you have accomplished.

Example Of A Themed College Application

Theme

Environmental Sustainability

Personal Experience

Volunteering at a local environmental organization

Goal

Pursuing a degree in environmental studies and working to promote sustainable practices in the business world.

Example in an Essay.

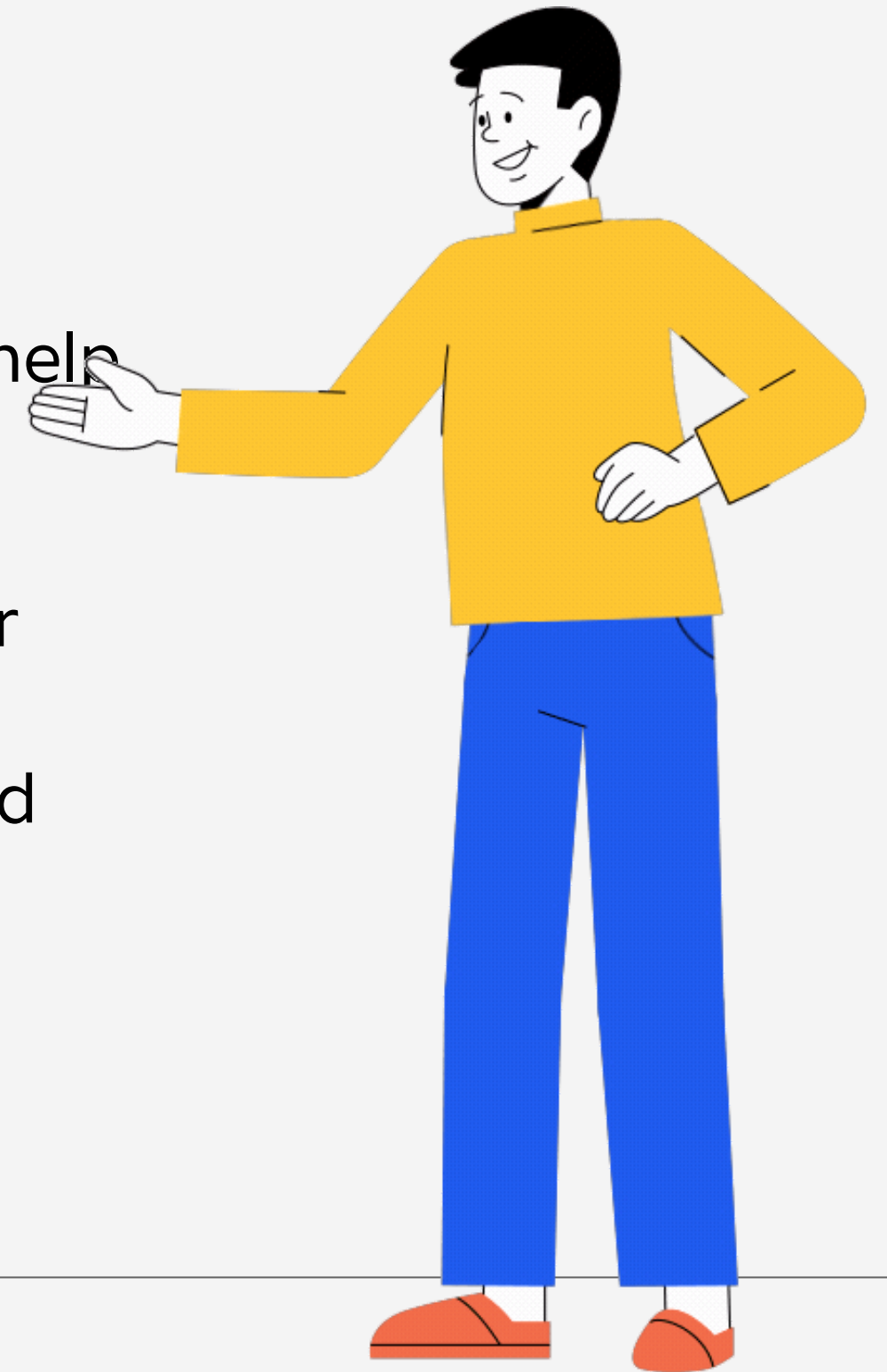
During my time volunteering at a local environmental organization, I was able to see firsthand the impact that environmental degradation can have on our communities. Through my work, I learned about the importance of sustainable practices and how they can help protect our planet for future generations. This experience inspired me to pursue a degree in environmental studies and to work towards promoting sustainable practices in the business world.

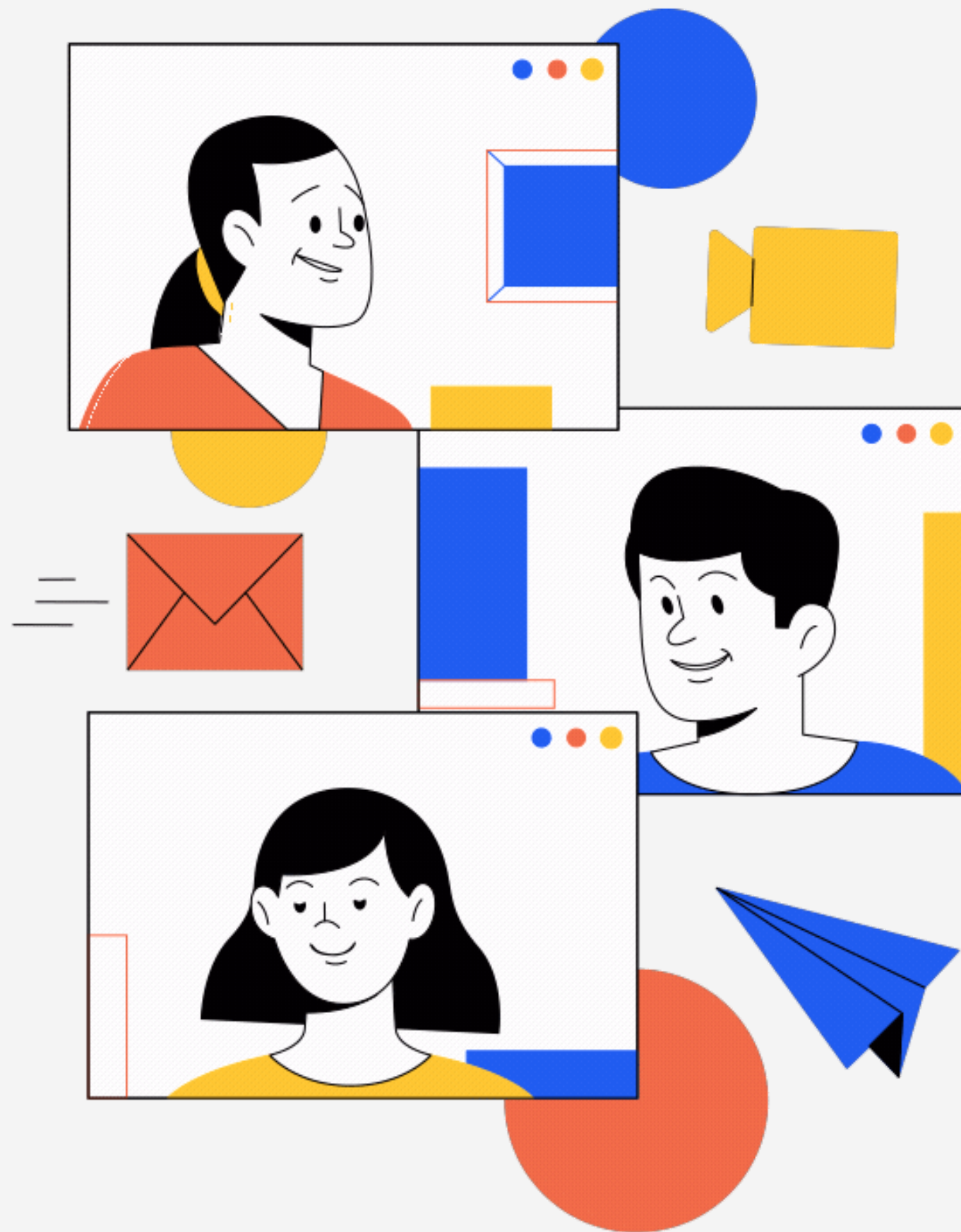
In college, I hope to take courses in environmental studies, business, and economics, and to participate in extracurricular activities that focus on sustainability. I also plan to seek out internships and job opportunities that allow me to apply my knowledge and skills in real-world settings. Ultimately, I hope to use my education and experience to promote sustainable practices in the business world, and to help create a more sustainable future for all.

In Conclusion,

Having a Theme in your college application can help you showcase your unique strengths and experiences, make a stronger impression on Admission Officers, and stand out from other applicants.

Just make sure that your theme is genuine and reflective of who you are as a person.





Thank you for attending!

ANY QUESTIONS?

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